FREE CLASSROOM KIT · GRADES 7-12

The Study Experiment

Your class studies two short texts, one by reading it twice and one by testing themselves. A week later, a surprise quiz shows which worked better. Students see the answer in their own scores, not in a poster about research.

Lesson 1

About 20 minutes. Every student studies both texts, one in each way. Keep the times exact, so that both ways get the same eight minutes per text.

Lesson 2

One week later, about 25 minutes. Do not warn the class: a quiz they know about turns into homework, and then the experiment no longer compares the two ways.

WHAT TO EXPECT

Expect a modest gap. In a class of 25, the class average will most likely favour the text students tested themselves on, by about half a question out of six. About half the students will score higher on that text, about one in five will get the same score on both, and about one in four will do better on the text they read twice. Roughly one class in fourteen sees no gap or the reverse. Many students will predict “about the same”. These numbers are our estimate from the research, not a promise.

MATERIALS

- Two short texts, Text A and Text B: one copy of each per student
- Blank paper for writing from memory
- Group cards and prediction slips for Lesson 1
- The quiz and score slips for Lesson 2
- A timer
- The results view on this page, or the board

BEFORE YOU START

1. Pick a topic area the class has not studied and will not study in the coming week. Lessons on the topic in between would change the result.
2. Make the two texts and the quiz with the prompt on this page, or use two textbook passages.
3. Read everything, check every fact, and make sure the two texts are about equally long and equally hard. For younger classes, keep them short and plain: if students can write down only a line or two from memory, the experiment shows little.
4. Print the texts, the quiz and, from the kit, the group cards and the slips.
5. Decide which half of the room is Group 1 and which is Group 2, and write it down.

The prompt builder and the results view are on the web page choosewise.education/study-experiment. Wherever this kit says "this page", it means that page.

TEACHER SCRIPT

Lesson 1

About 20 minutes. Every student studies both texts, one in each way. Keep the times exact, so that both ways get the same eight minutes per text.

1	2 min	Tell the class that today you will try two ways of studying. Do not mention a quiz, and do not say which way you expect to work better. Hand out the group cards: Group 1 to one half of the room, Group 2 to the other.
2	4 min	Hand out Text A. Everyone reads it carefully.
3	4 min	Group 1 reads Text A again and makes a mark in the margin each time they reach the end. Group 2 turns Text A over and writes down everything they remember for three minutes, then turns it back and marks what they missed.
4		Collect Text A and the written sheets.
5	4 min	Hand out Text B. Everyone reads it carefully.
6	4 min	Group 1 turns Text B over and writes down everything they remember for three minutes, then turns it back and marks what they missed. Group 2 reads Text B again and makes a mark each time they reach the end.
7	2 min	Collect everything, so that nobody takes a text home. Before anyone talks about the two ways, hand out the prediction slips. Collect them, sort them into three piles and write down the three numbers.

Group cards

Print one page for every four students.

LESSON 1

Group 1

1. Read Text A carefully. (4 minutes)
2. Read Text A again. Make a mark in the margin each time you reach the end. (4 minutes)
3. Read Text B carefully. (4 minutes)
4. Turn Text B over. Write down everything you remember, in your own words, until your teacher says stop. (3 minutes)
5. Turn Text B back and mark what you missed. (1 minute)

LESSON 1

Group 2

1. Read Text A carefully. (4 minutes)
2. Turn Text A over. Write down everything you remember, in your own words, until your teacher says stop. (3 minutes)
3. Turn Text A back and mark what you missed. (1 minute)
4. Read Text B carefully. (4 minutes)
5. Read Text B again. Make a mark in the margin each time you reach the end. (4 minutes)

LESSON 1

Group 1

1. Read Text A carefully. (4 minutes)
2. Read Text A again. Make a mark in the margin each time you reach the end. (4 minutes)
3. Read Text B carefully. (4 minutes)
4. Turn Text B over. Write down everything you remember, in your own words, until your teacher says stop. (3 minutes)
5. Turn Text B back and mark what you missed. (1 minute)

LESSON 1

Group 2

1. Read Text A carefully. (4 minutes)
2. Turn Text A over. Write down everything you remember, in your own words, until your teacher says stop. (3 minutes)
3. Turn Text A back and mark what you missed. (1 minute)
4. Read Text B carefully. (4 minutes)
5. Read Text B again. Make a mark in the margin each time you reach the end. (4 minutes)

LESSON 1 · CUT ALONG THE DASHED LINES

Prediction slips

Hand out at the end of Lesson 1, once the texts are collected and before anyone talks about the two ways. Students tick one box and hand the slip in. The slips are anonymous. Print one slip per student.

Which text do you think you will remember better in a week?

- ☐ The one I read twice
- ☐ The one I tested myself on
- ☐ About the same

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- ☐ The one I tested myself on
- ☐ About the same

LESSON 2 · CUT ALONG THE DASHED LINES

Score slips

Hand out once students have marked their own quiz and you have told each half which text they read twice. Students fill in both scores, fold the slip and hand it in. Leave a slip out of the results view if its box is ticked. Print one slip per student.

Text I read twice: _____ of 6

Text I tested myself on: _____ of 6

☐ I looked at one of the texts during the week.

Text I read twice: _____ of 6

Text I tested myself on: _____ of 6

☐ I looked at one of the texts during the week.

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TEACHER SCRIPT

Lesson 2

One week later, about 25 minutes. Do not warn the class: a quiz they know about turns into homework, and then the experiment no longer compares the two ways.

1	1 min	Tell the class there is a short quiz on last week's two texts. It does not count, and nobody will see anyone else's score.
2	8 min	Hand out the quiz. No texts and no notes. Q1 to Q6 are on Text A, Q7 to Q12 on Text B.
3	3 min	Read the answers aloud. Students mark their own answers strictly: an answer counts only if it matches the key.
4	1 min	Remind each half which text they read twice: Group 1 read Text A twice, Group 2 read Text B twice. Hand out the score slips. Students fill them in, fold them and hand them in.
5	2 min	Type the prediction numbers and the scores into the results view on this page, leaving out any slip with the box ticked, and show it on the board. A student can read the slips aloud while you type.
6	5 min	Talk about the result with the questions below.
7	3 min	Explain the three points below, so that every student can make sense of the result, whichever way their own scores went.
8	2 min	End with a plan: every student writes down when and how they will test themselves before their next real test. Close the book, write down what you remember, then check.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Think back to last week: which text felt easier to study, and what did you predict?
2. Which way won for you? Is that what you predicted?
3. What happened in the whole class? Why might the way that felt harder have worked better?
4. Why might some of you have done better on the text you read twice?

EXPLAIN THREE THINGS

Why reading again feels better. A text you have just read feels familiar, and familiar feels like knowing. Writing from memory is harder, and hard work feels as if learning is going badly. But recognising a text is not the same as recalling it when the text is gone. On a quiz straight after studying, reading twice often wins; a week later, testing yourself usually does.

Why your own result can go either way. Six questions per text is a small test: one lucky guess or one tricky question can change which way wins for you. The class result is a better guide than any one student's, and many studies are a better guide than one class.

Why it was not just the easier text. Half the class tested themselves on Text A and the other half on Text B. If one text was easier, it helped both ways equally across the class.

> ### If your result is even, or the other way round
>
> One class is not a study. With 25 students, chance plays a big part, and it takes many studies to see the pattern. Ask what might have affected your result: did some students already know the topic, was one text easier, did anyone go over a text at home? Then ask what each way felt like. Across studies in real school classrooms, testing yourself beats reading again when the test comes later, and your class has still felt why reading again is so tempting.

No computer? Ask for hands: who scored higher on the text they tested themselves on, who on the one they read twice, and who got the same? Write the three numbers on the board next to the predictions.

WITHOUT THE WEBSITE · FOR TEACHERS

Your own prompt

Fill in the blanks: the grade (it appears twice), your subject, the topic area and the language of the texts. Then type the prompt into any AI tool: Copilot, Gemini, ChatGPT or Claude. Read both texts and the quiz, and check every fact, before you print them: the AI proposes, you decide.

Do not include student names or student work in this conversation.

You are helping a Grade _____ _____ teacher run a classroom experiment on two study methods. Students will study two short texts: one by reading it twice, the other by reading it once, writing down everything they remember and then checking it against the text. A week later they take a surprise quiz on both texts.

Topic area: _____
Write everything in _____.

Write two texts, TEXT A and TEXT B, each on a different part of this topic area that students have not been taught yet.
- Make each text about 250 words, and keep the two texts within 20 words of each other in length.
- Make them equally hard: ten key facts each, similar sentence length and similar words, at a reading level for Grade _____.
- Spread the key facts evenly through each text. No headings or lists inside the texts.
- Use only facts that are well established and easy to check.

Then write a quiz: Q1 to Q6 on Text A and Q7 to Q12 on Text B.
- Each question tests a different key point of the text, the kind of thing a student would write down when recalling it. The answer is a word, a number or a short phrase from the text.
- Ask about what this text says, so that a student who has not read it cannot answer from general knowledge. Do not ask what a word means.
- Spread the questions over the whole text, and do not give away one answer in another question.

Reply in plain text, no tables, with exactly these five parts:
TEXT A: a short title, then the text.
TEXT B: a short title, then the text.
QUIZ: the twelve questions, numbered Q1: to Q12:, ready to print.
ANSWERS: the answers, numbered Q1: to Q12: to match, with other answers that should also count as right.
CHECK: every fact, figure, date or name in the texts that the teacher should verify, one per line.

Faster online: the prompt builder at choosewise.education/study-experiment fills this in for you. Students do not use AI in this experiment. AI tools have age rules that change often: check them on the web page, and check your national rules and your school policy before you start.